

Production Buddy

How-To Guide — step-by-step usage for each tab

v1.0.14

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Overview

Production Buddy is a macOS desktop app with three top tabs in the header. Each tab handles a different production workflow. This guide walks through every input on every tab, in the order you fill them in, using the same circled-number labels (①, ②, ③...) that appear in the UI.

Tab 1 — Marked-up PDF → InDesign Edits (*default tab*)

What it does: Reads reviewer markup from a PDF and applies the corresponding edits to the source InDesign or Illustrator file, then re-exports a corrected PDF.

Steps

- ① **Marked-up PDF** — Browse to the PDF that contains reviewer comments (strikethroughs, sticky notes, carets, highlights, etc.).
- ② **Source Document (.indd or .ai)** — The original InDesign or Illustrator file the markup applies to. The app auto-detects which engine to run from the extension.
- ③ **Output Folder** (*optional*) — Where the new .indd and exported PDF land. Defaults to the same folder as the source.
- ④ **Hi-res images folder** (*optional*) — A folder of hi-res stock-photo files. The app reads each placed image's stock-photo ID (Getty / AdobeStock / Shutterstock numeric ID) and re-links any watermarked comps to the matching hi-res file. Works with or without an ICF_ prefix.
- ⑤ **Reference files** (*optional*) — Other assets the markup mentions (extra .indd, .pdf, .ai, .psd, images). Used when the markup says things like “append the rebate sheet” or “place the logo here”.
- ⑥ **Brand Guide** (*optional*) — Browse to a brand-guide PDF (the official one for this brand) so the app can enforce approved swatches and fonts during QA. Tick “Save to memory” to add it to the persistent library; the next time you pick an .indd whose filename contains that name, the app auto-loads the saved guide. If two saved guides match, a picker pops up.
- ⑦ **508 compliance check** (*checkbox*) — Runs Section 508 designer-side checks: text/background contrast $\geq 4.5:1$, line weights $\geq 1\text{pt}$, alt text on images, document metadata (title/author/subject/keywords), and forces “Create Tagged PDF” on export.
- ⑧ **Click “Extract & Apply Edits”** — Watch progress in the status panel; QA findings appear below when complete.

Tab 2 — Batch Data Merge

What it does: Generates one .indd per record from a tagged template plus an Excel/CSV data source.

Steps

- ① **Tagged InDesign template (.indd)** — A template where placeholders are tagged like <<p l a c e h o l d e r >> instead of literal values. The app produces a p l a c e h o l d e r s . m d reference from your Excel files to guide tagging.
- ② **Data source** — Choose Excel files (one workbook with one sheet per record, row 1 = headers, row 2 = values) OR an existing CSV (row 1 = headers, one row per record).
- ③ **Per-record images folder (optional)** — A folder of per-record graphics named after each record. Supports .ai, .pdf, .eps, .png, .jpg, .tif, .psd. The app matches them by name and adds an @image column to the merged CSV — drag @image from InDesign's Data Merge panel onto a frame to auto-place.
- ④ **Output folder** — One file per record, named <Template>_<RecordName>.indd.
- ⑤ **Record-name column (optional, default "state")** — The CSV column whose value becomes the suffix in each output filename.
- ⑥ **Click "Run Data Merge".**

Tab 3 — Tag a Template

What it does: Takes an InDesign file built for a single record (e.g. one US state) and replaces that record's values with <<placeholder>> tokens, producing a Data Merge-ready template.

Steps

- ① **Untagged InDesign template (.indd)** — The original file built for one record. Save a backup first — the file is rewritten in place unless you supply an output path.
- ② **Excel data files (.xlsx)** — The same workbooks Batch Data Merge uses. The app reads the reference state's values to know what to look for in the template.
- ③ **Reference state** (*default "California"*) — The state your template was originally designed for.
- ④ **Output location** (*optional*) — Where to save the tagged copy. Blank = overwrite the original.
- ⑤ **Click "Auto-Tag Template"**.

Appendix — Settings (*gear icon, top-right*)

Classifier cascade

Rule-based matcher is always on. Optionally enable a local Ollama model to interpret ambiguous markup. Default Ollama model: `llama3.1:8b`. Everything runs locally.

QA thresholds

- Image min DPI — default **300**
- Max distinct fonts — default **4**
- Max body-text size for rich-black warning — default **14pt**

QA checks enabled

Toggle individual checks off if they're noisy for your workflow.

Output behavior

- Auto-relink missing assets from Box
- Auto-activate fonts via FontExplorer X Pro
- Auto-open PDF when complete
- Auto-open .indd when complete
- Show info-severity findings by default

Cache

Each run writes intermediate logs/JSON to `~/Library/Caches/indesign-editor/`. Default retention: **10** most recent runs.

Ignored findings

IDs you've dismissed will be hidden in future runs.